

# CHANGING HIS STRIPES

In a bid to regain power, Naidu abandons his techno-savvy image and goes rural but it's a strategy with many pitfalls

■ By Amarnath K. Menon

**N**. Chandrababu Naidu has taken on a new avatar in his bid to regain power but as things are turning out, he is realising that winning the Assembly elections next year will be no cakewalk. His 150-day odyssey, criss-crossing the countryside in a caravan, is proving to be the toughest test for the former chief minister and Telugu Desam Party (TDP) chief. As its intensity increases, the scorching summer is taking its toll on the driving ambition of the man who upstaged his father-in-law and party founder N.T. Rama Rao to become chief minister and then went on to rule for a full nine years.

The gruelling tour with the evocative name Mee Kosam (For Your Sake) Chaitanya Yatra attempts to present Naidu as a friend of the farmer and the rural poor. This is in sharp contrast to his earlier image of a techno-savvy politician who argued consistently that technology was the panacea for most economic ills plaguing not just the state but the country, glossing over the crying demands for basic issues like water and other amenities in the countryside. The new Naidu is a changed man. Beginning April 21 at a Scheduled Caste colony in Chandragiri, from where he was elected to the Legislative Assembly in 1978, Naidu now logs 50 to 80 km every day and passes through at least two assembly constituencies to make the all important rural connect for his electoral comeback. He stops for well-planned road shows to meet farmers, women, Dalits, Muslims and other disadvantaged groups. He listens to

them patiently and then assures them that he will set everything right on his return next year.

He likes to put certain questions to his audience before making any promises and enquires whether the people are getting subsidised rice, loans at low interest rates or clean drinking water, and then declares he will grant it all to change their lives for the better. He is banking on his promises to translate into votes. "Just wait for one more year. All your problems will be solved because we will surely win elections and form the government," he says, striking an optimistic note.

Naidu is quick to snub anyone raising a demand for a separate Telangana. He criticises the Government for its failure to check the rising prices of essential commodities and declares that his party will launch agitations and court arrests if the Government pressured farmers into repaying crop loans. On surface, Naidu seems to be satisfied with the response that he has got so far on the tour. "The time has come once again to instil a sense of Telugu pride among people and also expose the demonic governance of Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy. We will spend more time with the farmers and the poor to learn more about their problems during this tour. I am interacting

with a cross-section of people, including the poorest and telling them how the Congress Government is cheating them," he says.

But behind this public posturing Naidu is an extremely worried man. Dislodging the ruling Congress does not appear easy though he himself had helped NTR do it in the



past. In staging a comeback in 2009, he faces several challenges. Reddy—Naidu's earliest friend and mentor in politics—is a strong leader, who has aligned well with the rural voters. What adds to the TDP chief's discomfiture is the fact that the Congress is gleefully talking about the anomaly in his posture by recalling what he had stated in his biography *Plain Speaking* in English and *Manusulo Mata* in Telugu, published in 2003 when he was the chief minister. In it he had criticised free electricity for farmers and subsidised rice scheme. "Some may joke we are promoting his biography and thoughts but this is to debunk his pollspeak in favour of free power and free rice for the poor and tell people what his real thoughts are," argues Congress MP V. Aruna Kumar. "Naidu owes an explanation to the people as to whether he still supports what

The gruelling tour tries to present Naidu as a friend of the farmer but his opponents use it to mock his change of image.